



# Examining the Characteristics that Influence the Desire to Engage in Parasocial Relationships

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## ABSTRACT

The current study investigates the dynamics of parasocial relationships in social media to explore how the presence of vulnerability, humor, and higher perceived attractiveness influence individuals' connections with content creators.

## PROBLEM

### Background

With the increasing popularity of social media, there are opportunities for individuals to form parasocial relationships with a wide variety of content creators on social media platforms. A parasocial relationship is a one-sided, emotional connection that a person forms with a media figure or celebrity, typically through television, social media, or other forms of entertainment (Manolika, 2021). With the rising use of social media in our daily lives, parasocial relationships have become more prevalent among children, teens, and adults. This leaves room to question why exactly these parasocial relationships are so potent. There is currently a lack of research that examines the characteristics of content creators that may influence whether an individual desires to form a parasocial relationship. The current study examines the degree to which attractiveness, vulnerability, and humor associated with a content creator affects the desire that an individual may have in seeking a parasocial relationship with that creator.

### Hypothesis

We predicted that the characteristics of *Humor*, *Attractiveness*, and *Vulnerability* will play a significant role in the development of parasocial relationships between content viewers and content creators.

## METHOD

### Participants

The participants within this study consisted of college students attending a small private university in Texas ( $N= 78$ ). The participants within this study were volunteers.

### Procedure & Measures

Participants were placed at individual computer stations and were provided with headphones. Participants were required to watch a series of 1-to-2-minute videos, each video being constructed to show content creators expressing certain characteristics of humor, attractiveness, vulnerability, or lack of these characteristics. Following each video, participants were required to answer a series of questions regarding their connection to the content creators within the videos.

All participants were exposed to the same content and information. The survey questions were designed to measure the influence each of the above listed characteristics have on the participants liking of the content creators exposed to them throughout the experiment.



## DISCUSSION

This study delves into the intricacies of parasocial relationships within the realm of online content creators, particularly focusing on how the characteristics of vulnerability, humor, and perceived attractiveness of content creators influence individuals' connections with them.

The findings suggest a pivotal role of vulnerability in fostering connections towards content creators, and high levels of humor emerged as a significantly influential factor in electing positive responses from participants. However, the significance of vulnerability diminishes in scenarios where humor and attractiveness are the dominant factors. This suggests a nuanced interplay among these attributes in shaping individuals' perceptions and preferences regarding content creators on social media platforms. While attractiveness may initially capture attention, it is vulnerability and humor that appear to sustain and deepen these connections over time. The significance of vulnerability and humor in fostering parasocial relationships holds important implications for content creators seeking to engage and retain audiences. By authentically sharing personal experiences and emotions, creators can cultivate deeper connections with their viewers, thereby enhancing loyalty and engagement.

The use of a college student limits the external validity for a larger population, as parasocial relationships can vary across demographic groups and cultural contexts. Furthermore, this research focused primarily on the influence of specific traits on parasocial relationship formation, overlooking other potential factors such as content relevance, interaction frequency, and perceived reciprocity. Future research could adopt a more comprehensive approach to examining the multifaceted nature of parasocial interactions, considering a broader range of variables, their interrelationships, or other characteristics.

## RESULTS

A series of one-way ANOVAs and Tukey's HSD tests were preformed to determine which of the three characteristics of *Humor*, *Attractiveness*, and *Vulnerability* measured were most important to participants' liking of people within the videos.

**High Humor:** Data showed that the mean value of Humor ( $M = 79.526$ ) was significantly greater than both Attractiveness ( $M = 11.115$ ) ( $p<.001$ ) and Vulnerability ( $M = 9.359$ ) ( $p<.001$ ), and a significant difference was found between Attractiveness and Vulnerability ( $p<.819$ ).

**Low Humor:** Data showed that the mean value of Attractiveness ( $M = 15.808$ ) was significantly lower than both Humor ( $M = 41.526$ ) ( $p<.001$ ) and Vulnerability ( $M = 42.667$ ) ( $p<.001$ ), and no significant difference was found between Humor and Vulnerability ( $p<.969$ ).

**High Vulnerability:** Data showed that the mean value of Vulnerability ( $M = 80.936$ ) was significantly greater than both Humor ( $M = 8.282$ ) ( $p<.001$ ) and Attractiveness ( $M = 10.782$ ) ( $p<.001$ ), and no significant difference was found between Humor and Attractiveness ( $p<.752$ ).

**Low Vulnerability:** Data showed that the mean value of Attractiveness ( $M = 13.974$ ) was significantly lower than both Humor ( $M = 35.859$ ) ( $p<.001$ ) and Vulnerability ( $M = 50.167$ ) ( $p<.001$ ), and Vulnerability was significantly greater than Humor ( $p<.05$ ).

**High Attractiveness:** Data showed that the mean value of Attractiveness ( $M = 43.705$ ) was significantly greater than both Humor ( $M = 26.833$ ) ( $p<.01$ ) and Vulnerability ( $M = 23.462$ ) ( $p<.05$ ), and no significant difference was found between Humor and Vulnerability ( $p<.864$ ).

**Low Attractiveness:** Data showed that the mean value of Vulnerability ( $M = 58.962$ ) was significantly greater than both Humor ( $M = 27.936$ ) ( $p<.001$ ) and Attractiveness ( $M = 13.103$ ) ( $p<.001$ ), and Attractiveness was significantly lower than Humor ( $p<.01$ ).

**Totaled Individual Scores By Group:** Data showed that the mean value of Vulnerability ( $M = 271.551$ ) was significantly greater than both Humor ( $M = 219.962$ ) ( $p<.01$ ) and Attractiveness ( $M = 108.487$ ) ( $p<.001$ ), and Attractiveness was significantly lower than Humor ( $p<.001$ ).

The results propose that *Vulnerability* appears to precede both *Attractiveness* and *Humor* in importance to liking in a parasocial relationship, unless Attractiveness or Humor is the *dominant quality present* throughout a video.

Means of Perceived Characteristic Importance

